

Welcome to Our Maker Community: An Open Letter

Dear New Maker,

You just experienced one of our new initiatives at the Makerspace—events designed to share the joy of making with a wider audience and demonstrate how accessible the maker journey can be. As we prepare to unveil our larger space on the new campus next year, these initiatives are just the beginning.

The Makerspace has always been more than just a physical space. It's a vibrant ecosystem where ideas cross-pollinate and creativity knows no departmental boundaries. Let me share with you what makes this community special:

0.1 Our Current Landscape

0.1.1 Research Laboratory Support

We've become a hub for research apparatus development, supporting over 20 different projects across departments—from Biology to Psychology, Physics to Computer Science, Environmental Studies to Visual Arts. On any given day, you'll find PhD students and their mentees working here, creating an organic environment where knowledge flows freely between teams.

0.1.2 Plenary Projects

Our Leadership team, supported by community mentors and interns, tackles large-scale projects that push boundaries. These range from solving complex technical challenges through functional design to exploring new media art at the intersection of technology and expression.

0.1.3 Personal Explorations

Current Ashoka students use this space as their laboratory for personal projects. One of our community mentors, pursuing a self-guided independent project, recently received an invitation to present at a major accessible technology conference in Orlando next year. If you have ideas brewing, talk to us about funding opportunities and material support.

0.1.4 Student Society Initiatives

From fashion shows to electronics workshops to typing competitions, student societies have transformed this space countless times. The possibilities are truly endless—if you can dream it, you can probably make it happen here.

0.2 The Magic Between the Data Points

But what makes the Makerspace truly special are the moments that can't be categorized into data points:

- That impromptu conversation between a Math Professor and a Biology student about fountain pen designs that might lead to a patent
- The interdisciplinary project where performing arts students collaborate with CS folks, and a Math major discovers their passion for programming
- Those “shooting star” conversations that begin as casual chatter and evolve into 45-minute deep dives into how things work, leaving everyone enriched with new knowledge

Today, you became part of this community. The energy and connections we witnessed forming during the event are exactly what the Makerspace is about.

You're welcome to visit us between 11am and 6pm on working weekdays—until you become a community mentor with unfettered access, that is. ;)

Here's to making, learning, and growing together!

Originally written as a reflection after our first community-building event of the academic year 2024-25 (Let's Make: A Lamp!)

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